

AMOR FATI: HOW TO BECOME INDESTRUCTIBLE

And now, reader, time to part again.

I am in Amioun, the village of my ancestors. Sixteen out of sixteen great-great-grandparents, eight out of eight great-grandparents, and four out of four grandparents are buried in the area, almost all within a four-mile radius. Not counting the great-uncles, cousins, and other relatives. They are all resting in cemeteries in the middle of groves of olive trees in the Koura valley at the base of Mount Lebanon, which rises so dramatically that you can see the snow above you only twenty miles away.

Today, at dusk, I went to St. Sergius, locally called Mar Sarkis, from the Aramaic, the cemetery of my side of the family, to say hello to my father and my uncle Dédé, who so much disliked my sloppy dressing during my rioting days. I am sure Dédé is still offended with me; the last time he saw me in Paris he calmly dropped that I was dressed like an Australian: so the real reason for my visit to the cemetery was more self-serving. I wanted to prepare myself for where I will go next.

This is my plan B. I kept looking at the position of my own grave. A Black Swan cannot so easily destroy a man who has an idea of his final destination.

I felt robust.

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I am carrying Seneca on all my travels, in the original, as I relearned Latin—reading him in English, that language desecrated by economists and the bureaucrats of the Federal Reserve Bank of the United States, did not feel right. Not on this occasion. It would be equivalent to reading Yeats in Swahili.

Seneca was the great teacher and practitioner of Stoicism, who transformed Greek-Phoenician Stoicism from metaphysical and theoretical discourse into a practical and moral program of living, a way